Excerpts from Walden

Henry David Thoreau

1. What feeling is Thoreau describing by the pond? Underline the details he notices.

Thoreau feels peaceful and amazed by the pond. He sees it as a special place, almost as if it were high on a mountain. Underline these details in the passage: “high up on the side of a mountain,” “its nightly clothing of mist,” the mist “like ghosts” withdrawing into the woods, and the dew hanging on the trees later than usual.

2. What is the effect of the figurative language “clothing of mist” and “like ghosts”?

The “clothing of mist” makes the pond seem like it is taking off a covering as the sun rises. Comparing the mist to ghosts makes its slow movement into the woods seem quiet and mysterious. These images show how closely Thoreau watches nature and how much wonder he finds in it.

3. Why did Thoreau want to “live deliberately” in the woods? What did he hope to discover?

He wanted to focus on the essential parts of life and learn from them. He feared reaching the end of his life and realizing he had never truly lived. By experiencing life directly, he hoped to discover whether it was “mean” or “sublime” and understand it for himself.

4. Why did Thoreau believe that the woods would be the only place he would find the answers to life?

The woods gave him a place to live simply and pay attention to what was essential, away from many of society’s distractions. There, he could test life through his own experience instead of just accepting other people’s ideas. The excerpt explains why he chose the woods, although it does not directly say they were the only place where answers could be found.

5. What is the effect of the figurative language underlined?

“Suck out all the marrow of life” compares life to a bone with something valuable deep inside it. The images of cutting a broad swath and driving life into a corner make his search sound active and determined. They show that he wants to remove what is unnecessary and get to the truth of life, even if that truth is unpleasant.

6. Why does Thoreau use the simile that society lives like “ants”?

He compares people to ants to show how busy and small their lives can become when they are occupied with endless details. Like ants always working, people may stay busy without stopping to think about what is truly important.

7. How does Thoreau believe we should live? List two examples.

- Keep our affairs to “two or three” instead of a hundred or a thousand, so we can focus on what matters.
- Reduce unnecessary things, such as having fewer dishes at a meal, and live more simply.

8. What does he mean when he states that “We are determined to be starved before we are hungry”?

He means that people worry and hurry to prepare for possible future problems before they even face a real need. His example of taking a thousand stitches today to save nine tomorrow shows how preparation can become excessive and waste the life people are trying to protect.

9. How does Nature live deliberately?

Thoreau presents Nature as moving steadily without being rushed or thrown off course by small distractions. He wants people to follow that example by choosing how to spend their day calmly instead of letting every interruption control them.

10. Identify a metaphor in the last paragraph by underlining it. Then explain why Thoreau chose this comparison.

Underline: “Time is but the stream I go a-fishing in.” Thoreau compares time to a stream because it flows away, while “eternity remains.” He sees the stream as shallow and says he wants to “drink deeper,” suggesting that he wants to look beyond passing time and understand life more deeply.